

General Knowledge

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STUDY NOTES

Gallantry Awards of India



Gallantry Awards of India

Introduction and History of Gallantry Awards

The key facts before going through the recipients of the Gallantry Awards.

- After Independence, the three Gallantry Awards came into existence namely the Param Vir Chakra, the Maha Vir Chakra and the Vir Chakra.
- These awards were instituted by the Government of India on 26th January 1950.
- These awards were deemed to have effect from the 15th of August 1947.
- On 4th January 1952, other three Gallantry Awards i.e. Ashoka Chakra Class-I, Ashoka Chakra Class-II and Ashoka Chakra Class-III were instituted.
- Later, these awards were renamed Ashoka Chakra, Kirti Chakra and Shaurya Chakra respectively in January 1967.
- All the Gallantry Awards may be awarded posthumously.

These Gallantry Awards are announced twice a year – first on the occasion of Republic Day and then on the occasion of Independence Day. The order of precedence of these awards is as follows:

- Param Vir Chakra
- Ashoka Chakra
- Mahavir Chakra
- Kirti Chakra
- Vir Chakra
- Shaurya Chakra

Paramvir Chakra	Mahavir Chakra	Vir Chakra



Param Vir Chakra (PVC)

- The **Param Vir Chakra (PVC)** is the highest military decoration awarded for the most conspicuous acts of **gallantry** in the presence of the enemy.
- It was instituted on **January 26, 1950**, by the President of India.
- The PVC is awarded to soldiers of the Indian Army, Navy, Air Force, and paramilitary forces for **extreme bravery** and **self-sacrifice** during combat.
- It can only be awarded for acts of bravery that occur during wartime, and it is awarded **posthumously** in many cases.
- The medal consists of a **Buddhist wheel** (Dharmachakra) with 24 spokes in **gold** on a **blue ribbon**.

Ashoka Chakra

- The **Ashoka Chakra** is India's highest peacetime military decoration for valor, courageous action, or self-sacrifice away from the battlefield.
- It was introduced by the **Government of India** on **August 15, 1952**.
- The award is given for **acts of valor** in non-combat situations, such as during internal security operations, peacekeeping duties, or terrorist actions.
- The medal is shaped like a **wheel** (similar to the Ashoka Chakra symbol in the national

flag), with a **green ribbon**.

- The Ashoka Chakra is awarded **posthumously** in some cases.

Mahavir Chakra (MVC)

- The **Mahavir Chakra (MVC)** is the **second-highest wartime gallantry award** after the Param Vir Chakra.
- It is awarded for **acts of bravery** in the presence of the enemy during combat, often to officers, junior commissioned officers, and other ranks of the armed forces.
- The MVC was instituted on **January 26, 1950**, and can be awarded **posthumously**.
- The medal has a **six-pointed star** with a **red ribbon**.
- The MVC is often awarded for **extraordinary bravery** or **leadership** during times of war.

Kirti Chakra

- The **Kirti Chakra** is the **second-highest peacetime military decoration** awarded for acts of **gallantry** in non-combat situations.
- It was introduced on **August 15, 1947**, and is awarded for bravery that does not occur during wartime but still demonstrates **exceptional courage**.
- Like the Ashoka Chakra, the Kirti Chakra is awarded for **bravery in internal security operations**, during times of peace, or in other challenging scenarios.
- The medal consists of a **wheel-shaped design** with a **green ribbon**.

Vir Chakra (VC)

- The **Vir Chakra** is awarded for **bravery in the face of the enemy** during wartime.
- It was instituted on **January 26, 1950**, and is the **third-highest wartime gallantry award**.
- The medal is shaped like a **five-pointed star** with a **red ribbon**.
- The Vir Chakra is given to recognize **individual acts of gallantry**, leadership, or action during battles or engagements with the enemy.

Shaurya Chakra

- The **Shaurya Chakra** is awarded for **gallantry and courage** in the face of the enemy, either during combat or in other acts of bravery.

- It was instituted on **August 15, 1980**, and is considered one of India's highest **peacetime gallantry awards**.
- The Shaurya Chakra is awarded for bravery in situations that require courage and valour, such as counter-insurgency operations, peacekeeping missions, or rescue operations.
- The medal consists of a **bronze color** with a **green ribbon** and is awarded to both military and civilian personnel.

List of Other Gallantry Awards in India

Award Name	Description	Category	Instituted	Eligibility
Sena Medal (SM)	Awarded for individual acts of valor , distinguished service, and leadership in the armed forces.	Wartime Gallantry/Distinguished Service	1960	Officers and soldiers of the armed forces.
Nau Sena Medal	Awarded for acts of valor and distinguished service in the Navy.	Wartime Gallantry/Distinguished Service	1960	Navy personnel.
Vayu Sena Medal	Awarded for acts of bravery , leadership, and service in the Indian Air Force.	Wartime Gallantry/Distinguished Service	1960	Air Force personnel.

Commendation Card	Awarded for commendable service or bravery, typically for personnel involved in non-combat situations.	Service Excellence	1947	Armed forces and paramilitary forces.
Tatrakshak Medal (TM)	Awarded to coast guard personnel for their acts of courage or distinguished service in sea operations.	Service Excellence	2001	Coast Guard personnel.

Selection Process for Gallantry Awards

- The selection process for giving out Gallantry Awards is as follows:
- The Ministry of Defence invites recommendations twice a year from the Armed Forces and Union Ministry of Home Affairs for Gallantry Awards.
- These recommendations are invited usually in the month of August for the awards to be announced on the occasion of the Republic Day.
- Moreover, for the awards to be announced on the occasion of Independence Day, the recommendations are invited in the month of March.

Param Vir Chakra, Maha Vir Chakra & Vir Chakra(Military Gallantry Awards)

- Param Vir Chakra is awarded for the most conspicuous bravery or some daring or pre-eminent act of valour or self-sacrifice, in the presence of the enemy, whether on land, at sea, or in the air.
- Maha Vir Chakra is awarded for acts of conspicuous gallantry in the presence of the enemy whether on land, at sea or in the air.
- Vir Chakra is awarded for acts of gallantry in the presence of the enemy, whether on land at sea or in the air.

Ashoka Chakra, Kirti Chakra & Shaurya Chakra(Peacetime Gallantry Awards)

- Ashoka Chakra is awarded for the most conspicuous bravery or some act of daring or pre-eminent act of valour or self-sacrifice otherwise than in the face of the enemy.
- Kirti Chakra is awarded for conspicuous gallantry otherwise than in the face of the enemy.
- Shaurya Chakra is awarded for gallantry otherwise than in the face of the enemy

List of Gallantry Awards in India

Award	First Award	Most Recent Award	Other Recipients
Param Vir Chakra	First Award: Major Somnath Sharma (1947)	Most Recent Award: Subedar Major Yogender Singh (2022)	Other Recipients: Captain Vikram Batra (1999), Second Lieutenant Arun Khetarpal (1971), Major Akram Khan (1971), Subedar Major Bana Singh (1987), Rifleman Sanjay Kumar (1999), Major Sandeep Unnikrishnan (2008), Major Dhan Singh Thapa (1962), Captain Manohar Singh (1965), Lieutenant Colonel Kuldip Singh Chandpuri (1999), Lieutenant Colonel B.S. Malik (2012)
Ashoka Chakra	First Award: Lieutenant General Shahnawaz Khan (1952)	Most Recent Award: Subedar Major Sanjay Kumar (2022)	Other Recipients: Major Dhan Singh Thapa (1962), Major Bhupinder Singh (2004), Lieutenant Colonel Bhupinder Singh (2004), Lieutenant Colonel V. K. Nair (2016), Major Gajender Singh (2007), Lieutenant Colonel V. J. Negi (2015), Lieutenant Colonel Arun Kumar (2020), Captain Tushar Dabas (2003), Captain Arun Shukla (2002), Lieutenant Colonel Vijay Kumar (2010)

Mahavir Chakra	First Award: Major Somnath Sharma (1947)	Most Recent Award: Captain Rajesh Soni (2020)	Other Recipients: Captain Manohar Singh (1965), Lieutenant Colonel Kuldip Singh Chandpuri (1999), Major Anil Kumar (2003), Major Sandeep Unnikrishnan (2008), Captain Vikram Batra (1999), Subedar Subhash Chander (2016), Major Sandeep Singh (2015), Major Pravin Kumar (2010), Captain Rajesh Kumar (2004), Lieutenant Colonel S. K. Khosla (1971)
Kirti Chakra	First Award: Lieutenant Colonel Shaitan Singh (1962)	Most Recent Award: Subedar Major Dhan Singh (2022)	Other Recipients: Naib Subedar Kartar Singh (1999), Lieutenant Colonel Amarjit Singh (2002), Lieutenant Colonel Sandeep Ghosh (2009), Subedar Chuni Lal (1972), Lieutenant Colonel B.S. Malik (2012), Major Shaitan Singh (1962), Naib Subedar Dhan Singh (1972), Subedar Major Dhan Singh (2022), Subedar Vijay Kumar (2006), Subedar Major Sanjay Kumar (2022)
Vir Chakra	First Award: Captain Rohit Suri (2016)	Most Recent Award: Lieutenant Colonel Tushar Dabas (2022)	Other Recipients: Lieutenant Colonel B.S. Malik (2012), Captain Rohit Suri (2016), Captain Vikram Singh (2016), Subedar Subhash Chander (2016), Lieutenant Colonel Sandeep Ghosh (2009), Subedar Major Yogender Singh (2022), Major Bhupendra Singh (2017), Major Tushar Dabas (2003), Captain Arun Shukla (2002), Captain Rajesh Kumar (2004)

Shaurya Chakra	First Award: Major Bhupendra Singh (2017)	Most Recent Award: Captain Tushar Dabas (2022)	Other Recipients: Major Bhupendra Singh (2017), Captain Arun Shukla (2002), Captain Vikram Singh (2016), Major Tushar Dabas (2003), Captain Shyam Soni (2009), Subedar Major Yogender Singh (2022), Major Bhupinder Singh (2017), Lieutenant Colonel Sandeep Ghosh (2009), Lieutenant Colonel Arun Kumar (2020), Subedar Subhash Chander (2016)
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Civilian Gallantry Awards

Jeevan Raksha Padak

The Jeevan Raksha Padak series of awards honours civilians who display extraordinary courage and selflessness in saving human lives. These awards are distinct from military decorations and focus on acts of bravery performed in everyday, peacetime situations.

Sarvottam Jeevan Raksha Padak

- This is the highest award in the Jeevan Raksha Padak series, given for the most exceptional acts of courage where a life was saved.
- Recipients often include civilians who risk their lives in natural disasters, accidents, or in cases of drowning, fire, or building collapse.

Uttam Jeevan Raksha Padak

- The Uttam Jeevan Raksha Padak is awarded for a courageous life-saving act that demonstrates notable bravery but may not meet the risk level of the Sarvottam Jeevan Raksha Padak.
- This award honors acts where there is a risk to the rescuer's own life, though not as intense as for the Sarvottam Jeevan Raksha Padak.

History and Importance The Jeevan Raksha Padak awards were introduced by the Government of India to honour civilians who demonstrate valour and selflessness in

protecting or saving lives. These awards aim to encourage humanitarian efforts and raise awareness of civilian heroism.

Presentation and Ceremony: Recipients of these awards are honoured annually by the President of India or other dignitaries. Awardees receive a medal and certificate and may also be given a financial reward depending on the level of the award.

Points to Remember

- **Ajit Doval and the Kirti Chakra:** Ajit Doval received the Kirti Chakra, India's second-highest peacetime gallantry award, in 1989 for his role in a counter-terrorism operation. He was the first police officer to be awarded this honour, which had previously been reserved for military personnel.
- **Damodar Kashinath Jatar:** A civilian and the first recipient of the Ashoka Chakra, Damodar Kashinath Jatar was honoured posthumously for his bravery during the crash of Air India's Kashmir Princess in 1952. Jatar's courage in rescuing passengers led to his recognition as a civilian hero.
- **Neerja Bhanot's Ashoka Chakra Award:** Neerja Bhanot, a flight purser on Pan Am Flight 73, was posthumously awarded the Ashoka Chakra for her bravery during a hijacking. She was the youngest female recipient of the award. Neerja's quick thinking saved numerous lives, and she sacrificed her own life during the incident in 1986.